

UPSC GS-II POLITY

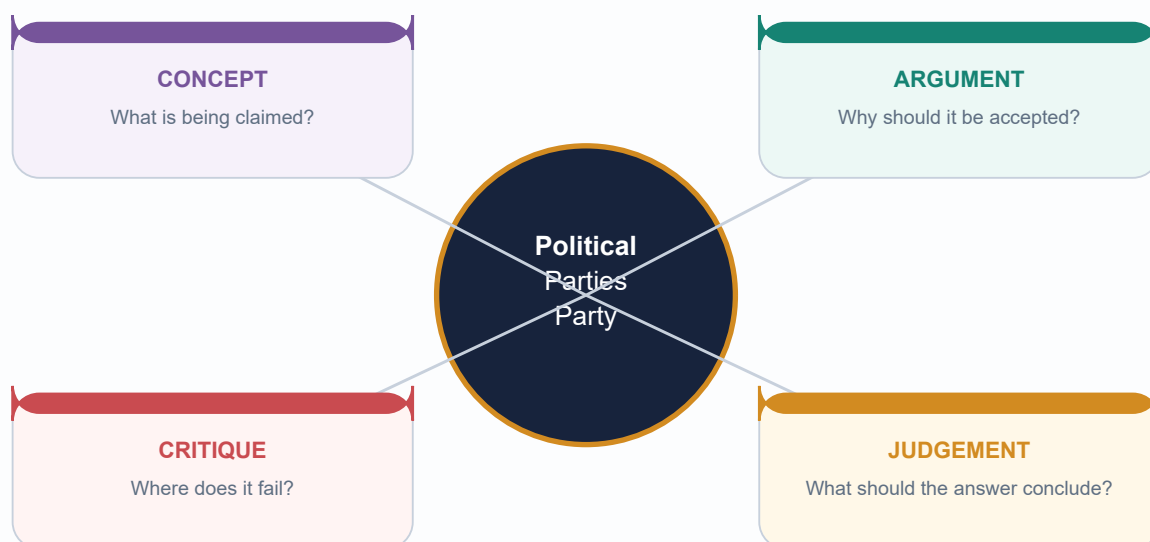
Political Parties and the Party System

Integrated Basic + Advanced Course

10 deep-learning modules | Congress System to Electoral Bonds Verdict

Recognition maps, comparisons, current-affairs anchors, UPSC traps and Mains frameworks

Prepared from the verified Polity knowledge base and the completed guided session



Facts from official sources | Inferences clearly marked | No fabricated data

HIGH UPSC RELEVANCE

HIGH

1. Evolution of the Indian Party System

GS-I / GS-II
Polity - Party
System

NEWS TRIGGER

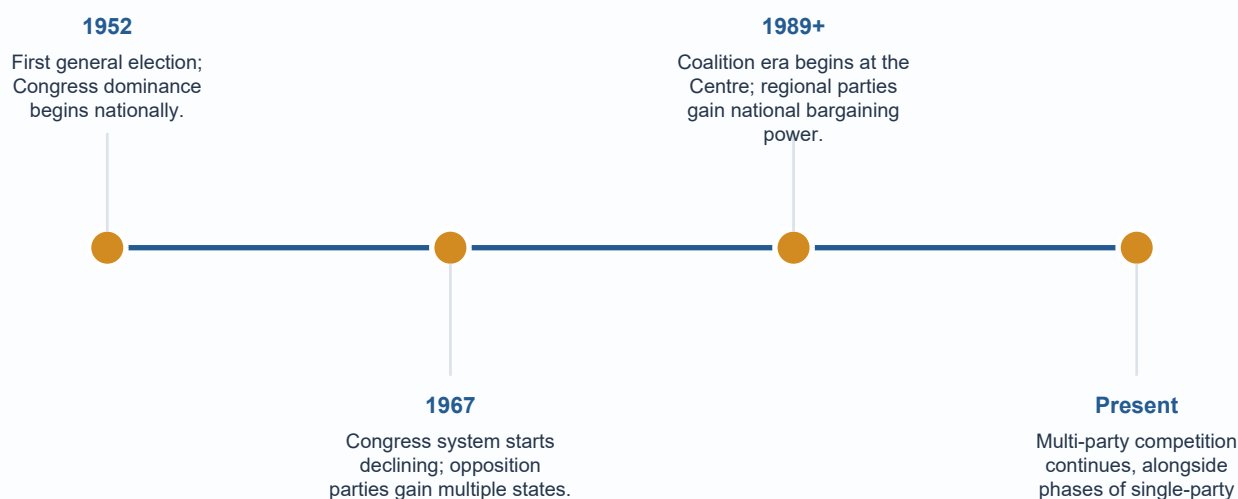
Discussions on coalition stability and single-party majorities regularly invoke Rajni Kothari's classic account of how India's party system has changed since Independence.

INTRO & ORIGIN

India has a multi-party system — the largest number of parties in the world — that has moved from one-party dominance to competitive, often coalition-based politics.

Rajni Kothari described the early decades as a 'one-dominant-party system' or 'Congress system', which declined after 1967 as regional and opposition parties gained ground.

PHASES OF THE INDIAN PARTY SYSTEM



STATIC THEORY

- India's party system is described as a multi-party system with the largest number of registered parties in the world.
- Rajni Kothari's 'Congress system' or 'one-dominant-party system' describes the early decades of near-total Congress dominance.
- This dominance declined after 1967, giving way to fragmented, often coalition-based politics.
- Indian parties are frequently criticised for lacking clear ideology (barring a few exceptions), relying on personality cults, and organising along religion, caste or language lines.

MEMORY HOOK

1952 = DOMINANCE BEGINS | 1967 = DECLINE BEGINS | 1989+ = COALITION ERA.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Rajni Kothari coined the terms 'one-party dominance' and 'Congress system' for India's early party politics.
2. India has the largest number of political parties of any democracy in the world.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: The Congress system describes a permanent, unchanging feature of Indian politics.

CORRECT: It describes the dominance of the early decades, which declined markedly after 1967.

MAINS ANGLE

Use the Congress-system-to-coalition-era arc to explain why India's federal and multi-party character makes it structurally different from two-party democracies.

STUDY LINK

Polity -> Political Parties -> Registration (Sec 29A, RPA 1951)

HIGH**2. Registration under Section 29A, RPA 1951**GS-II Polity -
Electoral Law**NEWS TRIGGER**

Every new party formation — from splinter groups to fresh regional outfits — must first pass through this single statutory registration gateway before contesting elections.

INTRO & ORIGIN

A political party must register with the Election Commission under Section 29A of the Representation of the People Act, 1951 before it can contest elections and seek recognition.

Registration is a statutory requirement, not a constitutional one — the Constitution itself does not mention political parties by name in this context.

FROM FORMATION TO REGISTRATION**STATIC THEORY**

- Section 29A of the Representation of the People Act, 1951 is the statutory basis for registering a political party with the Election Commission.
- Registration under a statute (not the Constitution) is the necessary first step; recognition as a national or state party is a separate, performance-based status granted afterward.
- Every registered party must commit to bearing true faith and allegiance to the Constitution of India.
- A registered party that has not yet earned national or state recognition is classified as 'registered-unrecognised'.

MEMORY HOOK

Sec 29A, RPA 1951 = REGISTRATION (statute) ≠ RECOGNITION (performance-based).

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Political parties are registered under Section 29A of the Representation of the People Act, 1951.
2. Registration and recognition (national/state) are distinct, sequential statuses.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Political parties are registered directly under the Constitution.

CORRECT: They are registered under Section 29A of the RPA, 1951 — a statute, not a constitutional provision.

MAINS ANGLE

Distinguish registration (a statutory formality open to any qualifying group) from recognition (an earned, performance-linked status) to correctly frame any question on party regulation.

STUDY LINK

Polity → Political Parties → National and State Party Recognition

HIGH

3. Recognition Privileges: Symbol, Star Campaigners, Broadcast Access

GS-II Polity -
Electoral
Privileges

NEWS TRIGGER

Symbol disputes between rival factions of a split party — as seen in recent state-level splits — are ultimately battles over these very recognition privileges.

INTRO & ORIGIN

Recognition as a national or state party brings tangible electoral privileges that registered-unrecognised parties do not enjoy, most visibly a reserved election symbol.

These privileges were designed to give organisationally significant parties easier campaign logistics, while smaller/unrecognised parties still retain a basic right to contest and pick a free symbol.

STAR CAMPAIGNERS: RECOGNISED VS UNRECOGNISED PARTIES

Recognised party



Registered-unrecognised party



A recognised party can field twice as many star campaigners, whose travel costs are not counted in candidate election expenditure.

KEY DATA

Privilege	Recognised Party	Registered-Unrecognised Party
Election symbol	Reserved symbol	Chooses from free symbols
Star campaigners	40	20
Broadcast time (state media)	Available	Not available
Nomination proposer	One proposer suffices	One proposer suffices
Electoral roll access	Available	Available

STATIC THEORY

- Recognised parties (national or state) get a reserved election symbol, unlike registered-unrecognised parties, which must pick from a list of free symbols.
- Star campaigners' travel expenses are not counted towards a candidate's election expenditure limit — recognised parties get 40 such campaigners, unrecognised parties get 20.
- Recognised parties also get broadcast time on state-owned media during elections, which unrecognised parties do not.
- Access to electoral rolls and the one-proposer rule for nomination are common privileges available across recognised and unrecognised parties.

MEMORY HOOK

RECOGNISED = RESERVED symbol + 40 campaigners | UNRECOGNISED = FREE symbol + 20.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Recognised parties get a reserved symbol; unrecognised parties choose from free symbols.
2. Recognised parties get 40 star campaigners; registered-unrecognised parties get 20.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Recognised and unrecognised parties get the same number of star campaigners.

CORRECT: Recognised parties get 40, unrecognised parties get 20.

WRONG: The Election Commission allots a reserved symbol to unrecognised parties too.

CORRECT: Only recognised parties get reserved symbols; unrecognised parties pick from free symbols.

MAINS ANGLE

Use the privilege gap between recognised and unrecognised parties to discuss whether recognition thresholds create a genuine level playing field for smaller or newer parties.

STUDY LINK

Polity -> Political Parties -> National Party Conditions

HIGH

4. National Party Recognition: Three Alternative Tests

GS-II Polity -
Election
Commission
Rules

NEWS TRIGGER

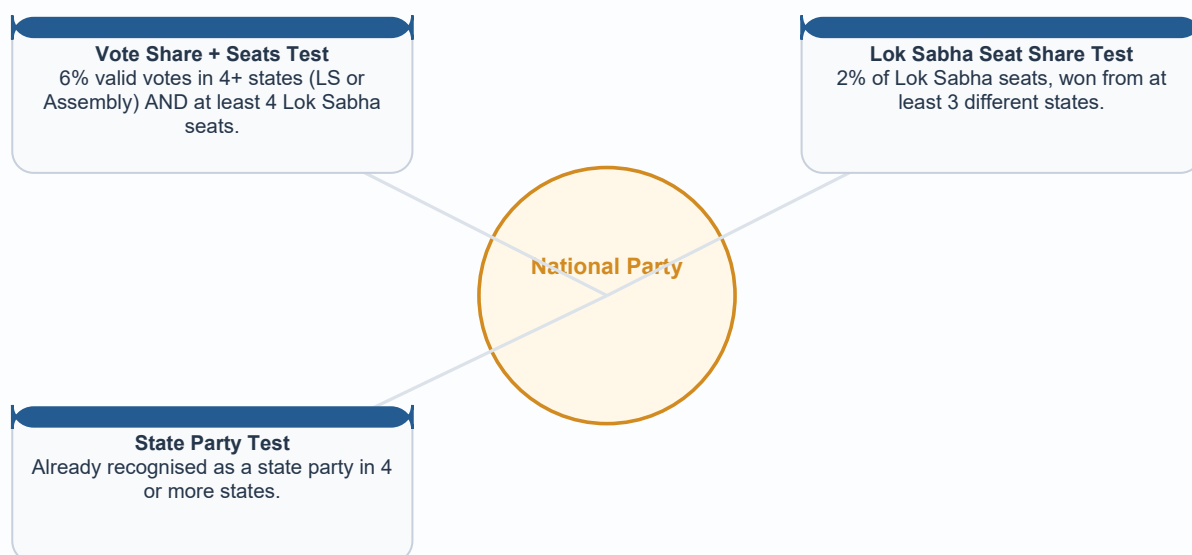
The Election Commission's periodic reclassification of national parties — most recently in April 2023 — is decided strictly against these three alternative statutory tests.

INTRO & ORIGIN

A party earns 'national party' status by satisfying any ONE of three alternative tests based on vote share, Lok Sabha seats, or existing state-party recognition.

The tests are deliberately set as alternatives (not cumulative), so a party can qualify through vote share, seat share, or multi-state recognition, whichever it achieves first.

THREE ROUTES TO NATIONAL PARTY STATUS



STATIC THEORY

- A party needs to satisfy only ONE of the three national-party tests, not all of them.
- The first test combines a vote-share threshold (6% in 4+ states) with a minimum seat count (4 Lok Sabha seats from any states).
- The second test is purely seat-based: 2% of Lok Sabha seats, provided they come from at least 3 different states (preventing a single-state seat concentration from qualifying).
- The third test recognises accumulated state-level strength: being a recognised state party in 4 or more states is itself sufficient for national status.

MEMORY HOOK

ANY ONE OF: 6% in 4+ states + 4 LS seats | 2% LS seats from 3 states | state party in 4 states.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. National party status requires satisfying only one of three alternative tests.
2. One test is 6% votes in 4+ states plus 4 Lok Sabha seats; another is 2% of LS seats from 3 states; the third is recognition as a state party in 4 states.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: National-party status requires 6% votes in all states of India.

CORRECT: It requires 6% votes in any 4 or more states (plus 4 LS seats), or one of the other alternative tests.

WRONG: A party must satisfy all three national-party conditions simultaneously.

CORRECT: Satisfying any ONE of the three conditions is sufficient.

MAINS ANGLE

Use the alternative (not cumulative) design of the three tests to argue that the ECI's recognition framework accommodates different paths to national relevance — vote share, seat concentration, or multi-state presence.

STUDY LINK

Polity -> Political Parties -> State Party Conditions

HIGH

7. The Electoral Bonds Judgment (2024): Transparency and Political Funding

GS-II Polity -
Political Funding
and
Transparency

NEWS TRIGGER

The Supreme Court's February 2024 verdict striking down the Electoral Bond Scheme remains the single biggest transparency-in-political-funding development of the decade.

INTRO & ORIGIN

The Electoral Bond Scheme (2018) allowed anonymised donations to political parties through bonds purchased from the State Bank of India, until the Supreme Court struck it down in 2024.

Association for Democratic Reforms v. Union of India, (2024) 5 SCC 1 (2024 INSC 113), decided 15 February 2024 by a five-judge Constitution Bench led by Chief Justice D.Y. Chandrachud.

FROM ELECTORAL BONDS TO THEIR INVALIDATION



STATIC THEORY

- Association for Democratic Reforms v. Union of India, (2024) 5 SCC 1, held the Electoral Bond Scheme unconstitutional for violating the right to information under Article 19(1)(a).
- The Court reasoned that anonymised political donations deprive voters of information relevant to an informed electoral choice, a right implicit in freedom of expression.
- The judgment directed the State Bank of India to disclose donor-donee linkage data, reversing the anonymity the scheme had guaranteed.
- This verdict is the most significant recent development in the law and politics of political-party funding in India.

MEMORY HOOK

2018 = SCHEME | 15 FEB 2024 = STRUCK DOWN (Art 19(1)(a), right to information).

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Association for Democratic Reforms v. Union of India, (2024) 5 SCC 1 / 2024 INSC 113, struck down the Electoral Bond Scheme on 15 February 2024.
2. The scheme was held to violate the right to information under Article 19(1)(a).
3. The SBI was directed to disclose donor-donee data.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: The Electoral Bond Scheme remains a valid, operative channel for political donations.

CORRECT: It was struck down as unconstitutional by the Supreme Court on 15 February 2024.

MAINS ANGLE

"Money power and opacity threaten Indian democracy." Discuss in light of the Electoral Bonds verdict and its implications for transparent political financing.

STUDY LINK

Polity -> Political Parties -> RTI and Political Party Accountability

HIGH

8. Current National Party Status: The ECI's 2023 Reclassification

GS-II Polity -
Current Affairs
(ECI-Verified)

NEWS TRIGGER

The Election Commission's order of 10 April 2023 reshuffled India's national-party list for the first time in years, a change every current-affairs-linked prelims question should account for.

INTRO & ORIGIN

The Election Commission periodically reviews national and state party status based on the latest poll performance; its 10 April 2023 order changed which parties hold national status.

The Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) gained national-party status in this review, while the Trinamool Congress (TMC), Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) and Communist Party of India (CPI) lost it.

KEY DATA

ECI Order, 10 April 2023	Party	Change
Gained national status	AAP (Aam Aadmi Party)	New addition to the national-party list
Lost national status	TMC (Trinamool Congress)	Fell below the qualifying thresholds
Lost national status	NCP (Nationalist Congress Party)	Fell below the qualifying thresholds
Lost national status	CPI (Communist Party of India)	Fell below the qualifying thresholds

STATIC THEORY

- The Election Commission's order dated 10 April 2023 is the operative current-affairs anchor for national-party status changes.
- AAP gained national-party status in this order, while TMC, NCP and CPI lost theirs.
- As officially checked against the ECI's notified list on 21 July 2026, there are six national parties: BJP, INC, CPI(M), BSP, NPP and AAP.
- National/state recognition is reviewed periodically, so this list can change again after future elections — candidates should verify against the ECI's current notification before an exam.

MEMORY HOOK

10 APR 2023: AAP IN | TMC, NCP, CPI OUT — six national parties as last verified.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. The EC's order dated 10 April 2023 made AAP a national party and withdrew national status from TMC, NCP and CPI.
2. As of the list checked 21 July 2026, there are six national parties: BJP, INC, CPI(M), BSP, NPP and AAP.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: TMC, NCP and CPI still hold national-party status today.

CORRECT: They lost national-party status per the EC's order dated 10 April 2023.

MAINS ANGLE

Use the 2023 reclassification to illustrate that party recognition is not a permanent label but a continuously reviewed status tied to actual electoral performance.

STUDY LINK

Polity -> Political Parties -> National Party Conditions

MEDIUM UPSC RELEVANCE**MEDIUM****5. State Party Recognition: Five Alternative Tests**

GS-II Polity -
Election
Commission
Rules

NEWS TRIGGER

Smaller regional outfits contesting only within one state typically qualify for recognition through these state-party tests long before they can meet the national-party thresholds.

INTRO & ORIGIN

State party recognition uses five alternative tests — more routes than the national-party test — reflecting the wide variation in how regional parties build their support base.

The fifth test (8% of total valid votes in the state) was added in 2011 to capture parties with a broad vote share but without the specific seat concentration the other tests require.

KEY DATA

Test	Requirement
1	6% votes in the state (Assembly) + 2 Assembly seats
2	6% votes (Lok Sabha, from the state) + 1 Lok Sabha seat
3	3% of Assembly seats, or 3 seats, whichever is more
4	1 Lok Sabha seat per 25 Lok Sabha seats allotted to the state
5	8% of total valid votes in the state (LS or Assembly) — added in 2011

STATIC THEORY

- Only one of the five alternative tests needs to be satisfied for state-party recognition.
- Tests 1 and 2 combine a vote-share floor with a minimum seat count in the Assembly or Lok Sabha respectively.
- Test 3 uses a proportional seat-share threshold (3% of Assembly seats, or 3 seats, whichever is greater).
- Test 5, added in 2011, is a pure vote-share test (8% of total valid votes) that does not require any specific seat count.

MEMORY HOOK

5 TESTS, any ONE qualifies — the 8% pure-vote-share test was added in 2011.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. State party recognition can be achieved through any one of five alternative tests.
2. The 8% total-valid-votes test was added in 2011.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: State party recognition has the same three tests as national party recognition.

CORRECT: State parties have five distinct alternative tests, not the same three as national parties.

MAINS ANGLE

Discuss how the wider range of state-party tests (five, versus three for national parties) reflects the Election Commission's recognition of federal diversity in regional party strength.

STUDY LINK

Polity -> Political Parties -> Categories Compared

MEDIUM

6. Categories Compared: National vs State vs Registered-Unrecognised

GS-II Polity -
Comparative
Analysis

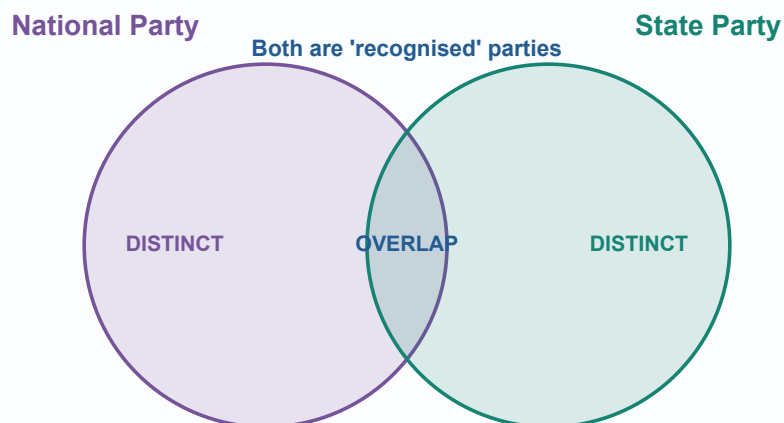
NEWS TRIGGER

The official list of six national parties (verified against the ECI's notified list, 21 July 2026) sits alongside dozens of state parties and hundreds of registered-unrecognised outfits.

INTRO & ORIGIN

All three categories — national, state and registered-unrecognised — can contest elections, but only recognised parties (national or state) receive the privileges tied to recognition.

The three-tier structure lets the Election Commission calibrate privileges to demonstrated electoral strength, while still allowing any registered party to contest without recognition.

NATIONAL PARTY VS STATE PARTY**National Party**

- Any ONE of 3 alternative tests
- 6 national parties on record (checked 21 Jul 2026)
- Recognition applies across India

Both are 'recognised' parties

- Get reserved symbol + 40 star campaigners
- Broadcast time + electoral roll access

State Party

- Any ONE of 5 alternative tests
- Recognition applies within the specific state(s)
- Larger and more varied set of qualifying routes

Registered-unrecognised parties sit outside this diagram entirely — they can contest, but without reserved symbols or the 40/20 campaigner privilege split.

STATIC THEORY

- National and state parties are both 'recognised' categories and share the core recognition privileges (reserved symbol, star campaigners, broadcast access, electoral roll access).
- They differ in scope (India-wide vs state-specific) and in the number of alternative qualifying tests (three for national, five for state).
- Registered-unrecognised parties can still contest elections and access electoral rolls, but do not get a reserved symbol or the larger star-campaigner quota.
- As of the officially checked list (21 July 2026), there are six national parties: BJP, INC, CPI(M), BSP, NPP and AAP.

MEMORY HOOK

NATIONAL (3 tests, India-wide) | STATE (5 tests, state-wide) | UNRECOGNISED (contest only, free symbol).

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. National and state parties share core recognition privileges but differ in geographic scope and the number of qualifying tests.
2. As of the list checked 21 July 2026, there are six national parties: BJP, INC, CPI(M), BSP, NPP and AAP.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: A 'national party' is required to contest elections in every state.

CORRECT: The label concerns recognition/privileges, not where the party chooses to contest.

MAINS ANGLE

Use the three-tier recognition structure to explain how India's electoral law accommodates both pan-India and purely regional political formations within a single legal framework.

STUDY LINK

Polity -> Political Parties -> Electoral Bonds Judgment

MEDIUM

9. Reform Debates: RTI, Inner-Party Democracy and Criminalisation of Politics

GS-II Polity -
Political Reform

NEWS TRIGGER

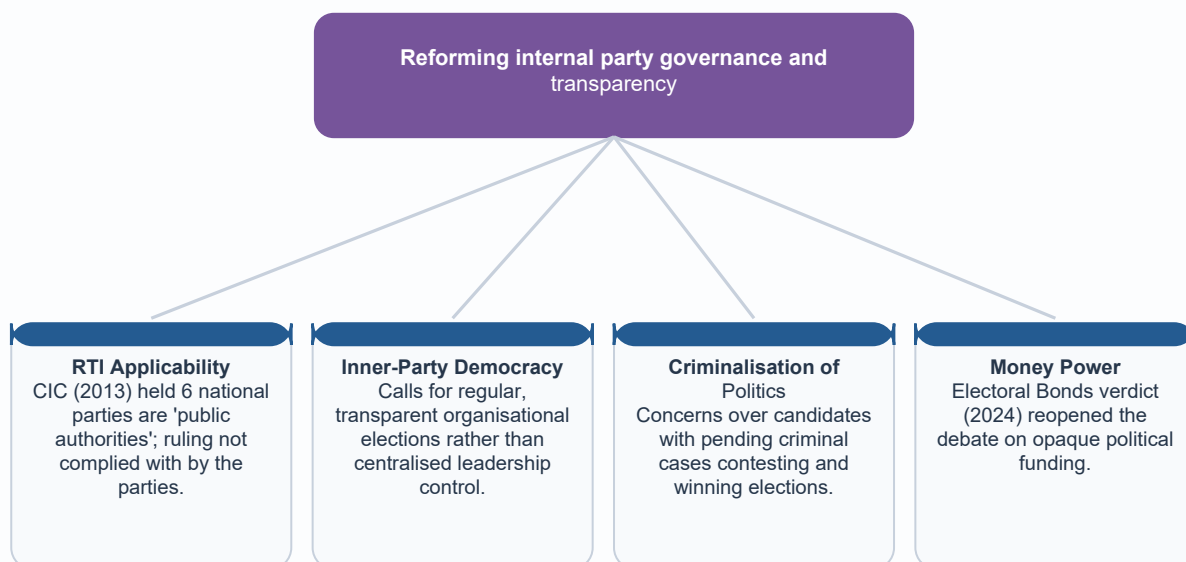
Every election cycle brings renewed calls to bring parties under RTI, hold internal elections transparently, and curb the entry of candidates with criminal backgrounds.

INTRO & ORIGIN

Beyond funding transparency, three linked reform debates recur: whether parties should be 'public authorities' under the RTI Act, whether they practise genuine inner-party democracy, and how to reduce criminalisation of politics.

The Central Information Commission (CIC) held in 2013 that six national parties are 'public authorities' under the RTI Act, a ruling the parties have not complied with.

SHOULD POLITICAL PARTIES BE MORE ACCOUNTABLE?



STATIC THEORY

- The CIC's 2013 ruling that six national parties qualify as 'public authorities' under the RTI Act has not been implemented by those parties.
- Inner-party democracy debates focus on whether organisational elections and leadership selection are genuinely transparent and contested.
- Criminalisation of politics concerns the rising number of candidates with pending criminal cases contesting and winning elections.
- These three debates, together with the Electoral Bonds verdict, form the core of the current political-party accountability agenda.

MEMORY HOOK

RTI (2013 CIC ruling, non-complied) + INNER-PARTY DEMOCRACY + CRIMINALISATION = the reform agenda.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. The CIC held in 2013 that six national parties are 'public authorities' under the RTI Act — a ruling not complied with.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Political parties are legally bound to comply with the RTI Act following the CIC's 2013 ruling.

CORRECT: The CIC's ruling exists but has not been complied with by the parties, and Parliament has not enacted a corresponding amendment.

MAINS ANGLE

"Should political parties be brought under the RTI Act?" Examine transparency versus organisational autonomy, using the CIC's 2013 ruling as the anchor.

STUDY LINK

Polity -> Political Parties -> Electoral Bonds Judgment

MEDIUM

10. Democratic Accountability: Parties as Vehicles of Representation

GS-II Polity -
Democratic
Theory

NEWS TRIGGER

Debates on regionalisation of the party system and on funding opacity both return to the same underlying question: are parties still effective vehicles of democratic representation?

INTRO & ORIGIN

Political parties perform core democratic functions — aggregating interests, recruiting leaders, and forming governments or opposition — but face persistent accountability gaps.

These accountability gaps — opacity in funding, weak inner-party democracy, and factionalism/defections — recur across the party-system literature and current-affairs coverage alike.

ROLE OF POLITICAL PARTIES IN INDIAN DEMOCRACY

Political Parties

Interest Aggregation Bring together diverse social, regional and economic interests into electoral platforms.	Political Recruitment Identify, train and field candidates for legislative and executive office.
Government Formation Form the government or a constructive opposition after elections.	Accountability Gap Funding opacity, weak inner-party democracy, and factionalism/defections remain persistent weaknesses.

STATIC THEORY

- Parties aggregate and articulate diverse interests into coherent electoral platforms, a core function in any representative democracy.
- They recruit and train political leadership, serving as the primary channel through which citizens enter formal politics.
- After elections, parties form either the government or a functioning opposition, both essential to parliamentary democracy.
- Persistent weaknesses — funding opacity, limited inner-party democracy, and vulnerability to factionalism/defection — constrain how well parties perform these functions.

MEMORY HOOK

PARTIES = AGGREGATE + RECRUIT + GOVERN/OPPOSE — but face funding, democracy and defection gaps.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Political parties perform three core functions: interest aggregation, political recruitment, and government/opposition formation.
2. Persistent accountability gaps include funding opacity, weak inner-party democracy and vulnerability to defection.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Political parties in India face no structural accountability challenges.

CORRECT: Funding opacity, weak inner-party democracy and defection vulnerability are well-documented, persistent gaps.

MAINS ANGLE

"Political parties in India are crossing the limits of democratic functioning." Examine the need for reforms in the working of political parties, linking funding transparency, inner-party democracy and defection resistance as three connected reform tracks.

STUDY LINK

Polity -> Political Parties -> Anti-Defection Law

End of Register Notes — UPSC Agent / Copilot CLI